

World Air Quality report: Sobering news for India

The latest **edition** of the World Air Quality report released by Swiss Air Technology major IQAir **has** **sobering** news for India. The country has 13 of the 20 most polluted cities in the world. The study is a reminder that though governments have taken **significant** steps to clean air — **at times** after being **nudged** by courts — the **interventions** have not **led to appreciable** improvements. The country is ranked the fifth-most polluted country, after Chad, Bangladesh, Pakistan and the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC). The IQAir list comprises not just urban centres whose **trysts** with **toxic** air are well known — Delhi and its **adjoining** areas for example — it also features small towns such as Byrnihat in Assam and Mullanpur in Punjab. This is not a new **finding**. In recent years, **towns** such as Bhiwadi in Rajasthan and Begusarai in Bihar **have** topped the IQAir list. But the country's pollution challenge continues to be **framed** largely **in terms of** a crisis in big city **governance**.

A knowledge base on pollutants in some Tier 2 cities is being built up **gradually**. **The number of** pollution monitoring stations **has** increased from 37 in 2015 to more than 1,000 (including manually operated ones) in 2023. These, however, represent less than a quarter of the country's requirement. Small cities remain underrepresented in research and policy. There is very little micro data on most of the 74 Indian cities listed in the IQAir report. According to a 2023 study by the Centre for Science and Environment (CSE), barely 12 per cent of India's 4,000 census towns and cities are covered under air quality monitoring **mechanisms**. The **analysis** by the New Delhi-based organisation **shows** that 62 per cent of the country's population is outside the real-time monitoring network. The other major problem is that despite the National Clean Air Programme's **emphasis** on targeted interventions over large areas, pollution **continues** to be seen as a local problem. Individual cities and states are, **by and large**, left to their own devices and even emergencies such as Delhi's annual health crisis do not lead to a **modicum** of cooperation.

The IQAir report **underlines** that pollution affects even the developed **economies**. However, the least developed and **emerging** economies are the most affected. India's neighbours, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Nepal, are among the poor performers. The problem's **transboundary** nature has been **evident** for long. In recent times, experts have been **advocating** interventions in multiple **airsheds** — contiguous regions — whose geography makes it difficult for them to **disperse pollutants**. However, **cooperation** between the South Asian neighbours **has** been **underwhelming**. The IQAir report is another reminder that such **intransigence** doesn't work.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Sobering** (adjective) – Serious, Thought-provoking, Grave, Alarming, Humbling
गंभीर
2. **Significant** (adjective) – Important, Notable, Considerable, Substantial, Meaningful महत्वपूर्ण
3. **At times** (phrase) – Sometimes, Occasionally, Periodically, Now and then, From time to time कभी-कभी
4. **Nudge** (verb) – Push, Prompt, Encourage, Prod, Urge प्रोत्साहित करना
5. **Intervention** (noun) – Involvement, Interference, Mediation, Intrusion, Intercession हस्तक्षेप
6. **Lead** (to) (verb) – Cause, Result in, Bring about, Produce, Trigger वजह बनना
7. **Appreciable** (adjective) – Noticeable, Significant, Considerable, Substantial, Perceptible सराहनीय
8. **Tryst** (noun) – Meeting, Rendezvous, Encounter, Appointment, Engagement मुलाकात
9. **Toxic** (adjective) – Poisonous, Harmful, Noxious, Deadly, Venomous विषैला
10. **Adjoining** (adjective) – Neighboring, Adjacent, Next, Bordering, Contiguous सटा हुआ
11. **Finding** (noun) – Discovery, Conclusion, Result, Observation, Outcome निष्कर्ष
12. **Frame** (verb) – Structure, Formulate, Shape, Design, Construct ढांचा बनाना
13. **In terms of** (phrase) – Regarding, Concerning, With respect to, In relation to, As for के संदर्भ में
14. **Governance** (noun) – Administration, Management, Rule, Control, Leadership शासन
15. **Gradually** (adverb) – Slowly, Steadily, Progressively, Step by step, Bit by bit धीरे-धीरे
16. **Mechanism** (noun) – System, Process, Procedure, Method, Structure तंत्र
17. **Emphasis** (noun) – Focus, Importance, Stress, Priority, Attention जोर
18. **By and large** (phrase) – Generally, Mostly, Overall, On the whole, For the most part आम तौर पर
19. **Modicum** (noun) – Small amount, Bit, Trace, Hint, Fragment थोड़ी मात्रा
20. **Underline** (verb) – Emphasize, Highlight, Stress, Accentuate, Reinforce जोर देना
21. **Economies** (noun) – Countries, Nations, States, Regions, Systems अर्थव्यवस्थाएं

22. **Emerging** (adjective) – Developing, Rising, Growing, Budding, Upcoming उभरते हुए

23. **Transboundary** (adjective) – Cross-border, International, Multinational, Global, Regional सीमा पार

24. **Evident** (adjective) – Clear, Obvious, Apparent, Visible, Noticeable स्पष्ट

25. **Advocate** (verb) – Support, Promote, Champion, Recommend, Endorse समर्थन करना

26. **Airshed** (noun) – Air basin, Atmospheric zone, Pollution zone, Air region, Airspace वायु क्षेत्र

27. **Disperse** (verb) – Scatter, Spread, Disseminate, Diffuse, Dissipate फैलाना

28. **Pollutant** (noun) – Contaminant, Toxin, Impurity, Waste, Emission प्रदूषक

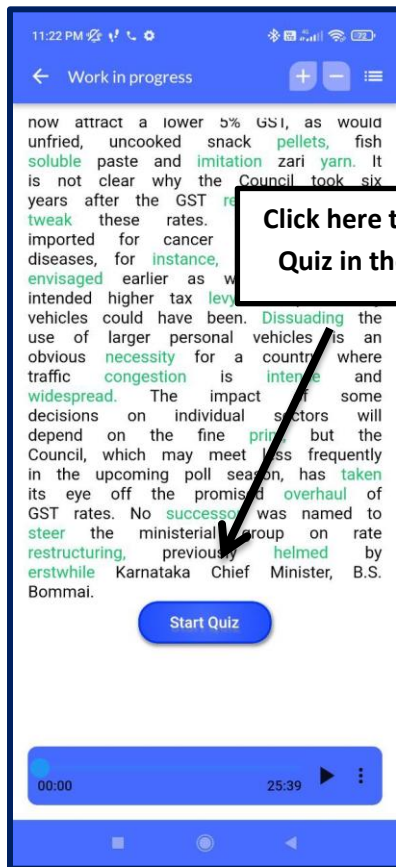
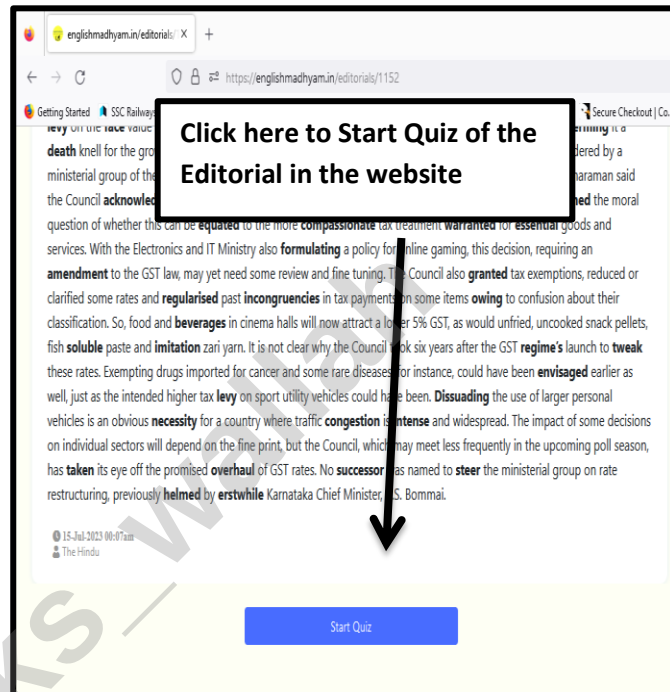
29. **Underwhelming** (adjective) – Disappointing, Unimpressive, Lackluster, Mediocre, Subpar निराशाजनक

30. **Intransigence** (noun) – Stubbornness, Inflexibility, Rigidity, Obstinacy, Unyieldingness हठधर्मिता

Summary of the Editorial

1. **Alarming Ranking:** India is ranked the fifth-most polluted country globally, following Chad, Bangladesh, Pakistan, and the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC).
2. **Most Polluted Cities:** India has 13 of the world's 20 most polluted cities, according to the IQAir report.
3. **Urban and Small Towns:** The list includes not only major cities like Delhi but also smaller towns such as Byrnihat (Assam) and Mullanpur (Punjab).
4. **Persistent Issue:** Previous reports have highlighted towns like Bhiwadi (Rajasthan) and Begusarai (Bihar) as pollution hotspots, indicating a widespread problem.
5. **Governance Focus:** Pollution challenges are often framed as a crisis of big-city governance, neglecting smaller towns and rural areas.
6. **Inadequate Monitoring:** Despite an increase in pollution monitoring stations (from 37 in 2015 to over 1,000 in 2023), they cover less than a quarter of India's requirement.
7. **Small Cities Neglected:** Small cities remain underrepresented in research and policy, with limited micro-level data available.
8. **Limited Coverage:** Only 12% of India's 4,000 census towns and cities are covered under air quality monitoring mechanisms.
9. **Population Outside Monitoring:** 62% of India's population lacks access to real-time air quality monitoring.
10. **Localized Approach:** Pollution is still treated as a local issue, despite the National Clean Air Programme's emphasis on broader, targeted interventions.
11. **Lack of Cooperation:** Even during emergencies like Delhi's annual air quality crisis, there is minimal cooperation between cities and states.
12. **Global Impact:** Pollution affects both developed and developing economies, but the latter, including India and its neighbours, are the most affected.
13. **Transboundary Nature:** The problem's transboundary nature is evident, with South Asian countries like Pakistan, Bangladesh, and Nepal also performing poorly.
14. **Airshed Approach:** Experts advocate for interventions across multiple airsheds (contiguous regions) to address the dispersion of pollutants effectively.
15. **Need for Regional Cooperation:** The report highlights the lack of cooperation among South Asian neighbours and emphasizes the need for collaborative efforts to tackle air pollution.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based

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